

Code for Good 2026 - Hyderabad

Challenge Statement 2(Mentoring)

Organization Overview

Name: Barabari Collective

Website: <https://barabaricollective.org/>

Mission: Barabari Collective is a future-of-work organization focused on enabling graduates from low-income communities to build high-growth careers in the digital economy. It works with government and higher-education ecosystems to provide industry-oriented technical and workplace skills. Through its programs, students gain practical experience by working on real-world industry projects and accessing mentorship and employment pathways. Barabari aims to bridge the gap between higher education and meaningful economic opportunities by connecting learning with real-world experience and employment.

Problem Context

Barabari Collective prepares higher-education students for employment by combining skill development with practical, real-world experience. As part of this journey, students get opportunities to work on projects brought to Barabari by external clients, startups, small companies, and independent freelancers. Students work directly with these external stakeholders while senior mentors provide guidance on project scoping, architecture, development, deployment, and other technical aspects.

While this model gives students valuable experience working on real projects, students often require frequent support throughout the engagement. As a result, students frequently reach out to mentors through support tickets, chats, or calls, even for issues that could potentially be handled independently.

As multiple projects run simultaneously, this creates repeated manual effort for mentors and can make it difficult for them to focus their time on higher-level guidance where their expertise is most needed. Barabari also needs to maintain visibility into project progress and outstanding issues across students, mentors, and external stakeholders.

The opportunity, therefore, is not simply to provide students with another source of technical assistance, but to enable them to work more independently on real-world projects while improving how project knowledge, client requirements, and support needs are managed. The challenge is open to exploring different technological and process-based approaches, rather than assuming that a chatbot or AI-powered assistant is the solution. The goal is to help students

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navigate their projects more effectively, allowing mentors to focus on higher-value guidance and helping Barabari scale its project-based learning model.

Current State and Technology Baseline: How do things work today

Barabari currently supports students working on real-world projects brought by external clients, startups, small companies, and independent freelancers. Once a project is identified, Barabari uses its existing student metrics and dashboards to identify suitable students, with mentors providing guidance throughout the engagement.

A typical project workflow involves:

- External client/project identified → student selection → mentor + client discussions → execution with mentor support → completion
- Students and mentors join initial client discussions to align on scope, requirements, and technical approach (incl. architecture)
- During execution, students raise support tickets when help is needed; mentors respond via calls and support on troubleshooting, code reviews, deployments, and related issues
- Mentors also join regular client/project calls and often reiterate or simplify requirements/decisions for students
- At the Barabari level, Project progress and outstanding issues are reviewed through a recurring process

The current approach creates recurring mentor load and scaling constraints:

- High dependency on mentors for routine questions
- Misinterpretation of client requirements leads to rework and delays
- Repeated context re-explanation across students/projects increases manual effort
- Mentor time is split between high-value guidance (scoping/architecture) and lower-level execution support (coding/reviews/deployments)
- As concurrent projects increase, the mentor support model becomes harder to sustain
- Progress visibility relies on periodic updates/manual follow-ups, while day-to-day support is fragmented across tickets/chats/calls

Challenge Statement

Barabari Collective currently relies heavily on mentors to support students with client communication, requirement clarification, technical issues, code reviews, and project execution. While mentor involvement is valuable for areas such as architecture and key technical decisions, students frequently seek help with routine questions, requiring mentors to repeatedly understand project context, resolve issues, and re-explain client requirements.

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How might we help students work more independently by improving their understanding and communication of client requirements and enabling them to navigate common project challenges, while allowing mentors to focus their time on higher-level guidance and intervention where it is most needed?

At its core, this challenge is about reducing routine mentor dependency while helping students take greater ownership of their projects.

Stakeholder Universe

Primary stakeholders

- **Students:** The primary users and beneficiaries of the project-based freelancing model. They work directly with external clients on real-world projects and need to understand requirements, communicate effectively, resolve project issues, and complete tasks with appropriate mentor support.
- **Mentors:** Provide technical and project guidance to students, including support with project scoping, architecture, coding, code reviews, deployments, and client discussions. They are directly affected by the amount of routine student support and repeated clarification required across projects.
- **External Clients/Freelancers:** Bring real-world projects to Barabari and work with students to define requirements, provide feedback, and review project outcomes. Clear communication with students is important for ensuring that project expectations and deliverables are understood.

Secondary stakeholders

- **Barabari Team:** Coordinates the overall project engagements, student assignments, and mentor support. They monitor project progress and outstanding issues and intervene when coordination between students and mentors breaks down.

Data Landscape

- **Project artifacts:** Project briefs, client requirements, expected deliverables, and available technical documentation, including architecture, code, and deployment resources.
- **Student support records:** Existing support tickets, student queries, mentor responses, and examples of recurring technical or project-related issues, where available.
- **Project communication records:** Available notes or records from client–student and student–mentor discussions, including requirement clarifications, technical decisions, and project updates.

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- **Existing project management platform:** Barabari currently use ClickUp (a project management platform) for managing support tickets and project-related activities, along with weekly project status updates and outstanding issues.

Key Constraints and Considerations

- **Student independence:** Help students solve common issues on their own; escalate to mentors when needed.
- **Context-aware support:** Tailor guidance to the project's requirements, client expectations, and current stage.
- **Reliable information:** Ground support in project artifacts, prior project knowledge, and past mentor guidance.
- **Human-in-the-loop:** Flag cases needing mentor intervention; keep mentors focused on complex/unresolved issues.
- **Client communication:** Improve how students interpret requirements and communicate updates, questions, and risks.
- **Scalability:** Scale across more students/projects without increasing mentor workload proportionally.